

S. Europe

The Doge's Palace

A lavish building that embodies the glory and cruelty of the historic Venetian republic

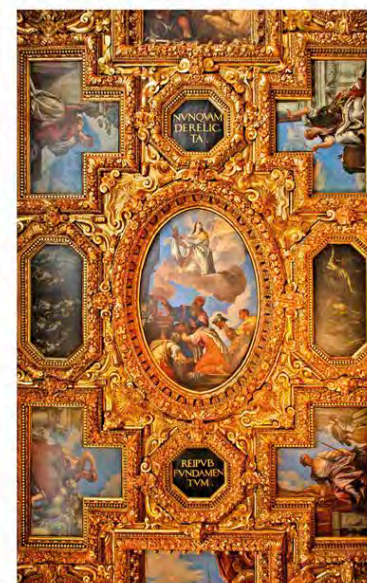
For more than a thousand years, from 726 to 1797, the maritime city-state of Venice was a republic ruled by an elected doge, or duke. The luxurious palace built for the doge and his administration in the 14th and 15th centuries displays the extraordinary wealth and influence the city had attained by that point in its history through the skill of its sailors and the rapacity of its merchants. Much of Venice's trade was with the Muslim world, and this is reflected in the unique style of the palace's facades, which give a distinctively Islamic twist to European Gothic architecture.

Center of law and government

The palace fulfilled a range of functions, serving as living quarters for the doge, government offices, a venue for receiving foreign ambassadors, a

parliament, a courthouse, and a prison. The vast rooms of the state apartments are embellished with scores of paintings by Renaissance artists, mostly trumpeting the glories and triumphs of the Venetian republic.

The palace also holds plentiful evidence of the darker aspects of the Venetian state, which earned a fearsome reputation for ruthlessness and secrecy. Political prisoners, tried in secret, were incarcerated in cells under the roof of the palace, known as the *Piombi* (the "leads"), or in the gloomy basement rooms of the *Pozzi* (the "wells"). A new prison was built alongside the palace in 1600, connected to it by the elegant Bridge of Sighs, named for the prisoners' presumed expressions of woe. After the end of the era of the doges, the palace still housed administrative offices until 1923, when it became a museum and found its modern vocation as a magnet for tourists.



△ LAVISH CEILINGS

The palace's state rooms have ornate gilded ceilings embellished with paintings by Venetian Renaissance masters such as Veronese and Tintoretto.

The palace contains one of the **world's largest** oil paintings, **Tintoretto's *Paradise***



◁ ANGEL STATUE

This stone angel is one of the figures placed at the corners of the facade of the Doge's Palace. The startlingly original building created a distinctive Venetian Gothic style of architecture.

△ FLOATING PALACE

The palace seems to float on its own reflection. Built of brick with marble facing, it is a light structure suited to stand on foundations in island mud.

VENETIAN GOTHIC STYLE

The facades of the palace have open arcades on the lower two floors, with typically Venetian Gothic pointed arches. The delicately carved stonework of the capitals and quatrefoils above the columns gives a magical effect of lightness. The upper wall is faced with pink and white marble in a bold decorative pattern.

